basis of 2011 population when we are in 2023. Had the census been conducted in 2021, we would have had many more beneficiaries. We have carried out a survey and will cover those people too.

Q. The central investigative agencies have recovered cash from even IAS officers, politicians and officers connected to the CMO. What do you have to say?

The Rs 50 lakh that has been found is linked to an officer and his in-laws who are from a strong financial background. In neighbouring Madhya Pradesh, clerks have been found with Rs 50 lakh. Also, the agencies claim corruption to the tune of Rs 2,000 crore, sometimes to the tune of Rs 500 crore. They should also say where the property they are talking about is.

Q. How is your relationship with your colleague T.S. Singh Deo? Will your present relationship impact the party's prospects in the upcoming polls?

Recently, a divisional conference was held at Surguja (Singh Deo's turf) and all issues have been clarified. We are together and it will be evident in the next election.

party feels these moves—in keeping with Congress leaders' temple runs and public prayers, not to mention visits to influential godmen and holding of *kathas* and *bhandaras*—will negate any chances of votes moving to the BJP on religious grounds. Baghel denies this (see *interview*) claiming that his pitch is inclusive.

One of the most ambitious projects under the 'soft Hindutva' banner is the Ram Van Gaman Path or development of sites that Lord Ram is said to have crossed en route to Lanka. This was in the election manifestos of the Congress both in MP (where a BJP government replaced the Congress gone in 2020) and Chhattisgarh. In Chhattisgarh, work has commenced on nine sites from the north to the south—Sitamarhi, Ramgarh, Shivrinarayan, Turturiya, Chandkhuri, Rajim, Sihawa, Jagdalpur and Ramaram.

Building an effective caste alliance is key to winning any electoral contest and Chhattisgarh is no exception. Both the Congress and the BJP are looking at victory through the OBC vote. While the BJP set the tone for the contest by appointing Bilaspur MP Arun Sao as state BJP president and Narayan Chandel, another OBC, as the leader of the Opposition, the Congress is trying to stitch up a Kurmi-Yadav-Marar-Agariya-Patel alliance. Sahus, to which Sao belongs, are the biggest OBC community in the state, followed by the Kurmis, the community Baghel hails from. Since most of Baghel's work is focused on the central region of the state through the farm sector, which is dominated by OBCs, the Congress feels it will be able to make an impact on all OBC communities. Besides this, the party thinks that the tribals will stand by them. The recent defection of the state's top BJP tribal leader Nand Kumar Sai to the Congress is being cited as something that will help the Congress further consolidate itself in the tribal North and South.

Another community present in fairly large numbers in the central region is the Satnami, classified as a Scheduled Caste. Politically active and aware, the Satnamis have traditionally been Congress voters but have also supported the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) in certain areas. In the 2018 election, the Janta Congress Chhattisgarh-Jogi (JCC-J) and the BSP secured about 12 per cent of the vote and won seven seats. With the JCC-J now diminished and the BSP weakened, the Satnami support can go anywhere. Baghel sees an advantage here, given that Rudra Guru, the son of one of their prominent gurus, is in the cabinet. However, newer players such as the Aam Aadmi Party are also trying to woo the Satnami vote. The BJP is in talks with another guru of the community, Baalak Das, and is hopeful that the tensions between Kurmis and Satnamis will help it win the latter's support.

Even though surveys have predicted Baghel being ahead in Chhattisgarh, the outcome is not a foregone conclusion. The BJP has been well established in the state right from the Jan Sangh days. Corruption is an issue, which the BJP has been hammering, with cash seizures from IAS officers in Enforcement Directorate (ED) searches adding to the charges. Congress leaders like Anwar Dhebar are in jail as are Baghel's most trusted official Saumya Chaurasia and IAS officer Sameer Vishnoi. Baghel says the ED and Income Tax Department are politically motivated and have not been able to prove much.

There are also fissures within the Congress, which if not smoothened out, may lead to problems for the party. The elevation of Singh Deo as deputy CM may be a step in that direction but if his grievance that officials in his constituency and around it were deliberately not addressing his legitimate demands at the behest of Baghel is not addressed, it could spell trouble for the party in the tribal-dominated North and South.

There are also Baghel's differences with Markam, which remain unresolved. In an election year, the Congress can ill-afford to have the party and government pulling in different directions. Insiders suggest Baghel wants Markam replaced with another tribal leader, probably Deepak Baij or Amarjeet Bhagat, before the election. Others feel it is too close to the polls for a change. Infighting is bound to erupt as the Congress plans to deny tickets to 30-40 per cent of the sitting MLAs, many of them first-timers, who have failed to get a hang of their non-legislative work as MLAs.

The Congress also appears clearly weak in 20-odd seats located in the urban areas—primarily owing to the slowing down of maintenance of roads and parks, civic amenities and creation of new infrastructure. The pace of development of the new capital, Naya Raipur, though on, is tardy too. The Congress will need to shape up in urban areas, or be voted out. ■